

Darwin Core Maintenance Group call

2026-07-06 12:30 UTC

Attendees: Steve Baskauf, Tim Robertson, Jorg Holetschek., Peter Desmett, Cecilie Svenningsen, Kate Ingenloff, John Wiczorek, Ben Norton

Regrets: Paula Z

Notes:

This is the first of our regularly scheduled (monthly) Maintenance Group meetings. The next meeting should be on 3 August 2026 (the first Monday) at 12:30 UTC.

- I. Discussion of criteria for borrowing terms into Darwin Core from outside of the standard.
 - A. With the arrival of Darwin Core DP (DwC-DP), there are now terms used in schemas that are from outside Darwin Core. There is no requirement that all terms used in DwC-DP be part of one of the Darwin Core vocabularies (main, Chronometric Age, and Humboldt), but in some cases we have opted to officially add them to our vocabularies.
 - B. Explanation of how outside terms are used in schemas.
 - C. See umbrella issue for GBIF terms <https://github.com/tdwg/dwc/issues/907>
 - D. Possible criteria for inclusion (use as column headers?)

Conclusion: we won't include them unless someone demonstrates a need for it.

- II. Are schemas normative or non-normative?
 - A. Definitions from the Standards Documentation Specification (<https://sds.tdwg.org/specification#15-definitions>):
 1. **Normative content** - prescriptive parts of a standard that specify features, characteristics, or behaviors that are necessary to comply with the standard.
 2. **Non-normative content** - informative parts of a standard that provide supplemental information such as history, examples, and additional explanation beyond the information necessary to comply with the standard.
 - B. In addition to these definitions, there is a difference in the level of difficulty in changing content between these two categories. In section 3.4.3 of the Vocabulary Maintenance Specification (<https://vms.tdwg.org/specification#34-changes-to-documents-supporting-the-vocabulary>), it is required that changes involving normative content must go through the full change process, while there is more discretion about the extent of community involvement in changes to non-normative content. It's more important for normative content to be stable, thus, it's harder to change.

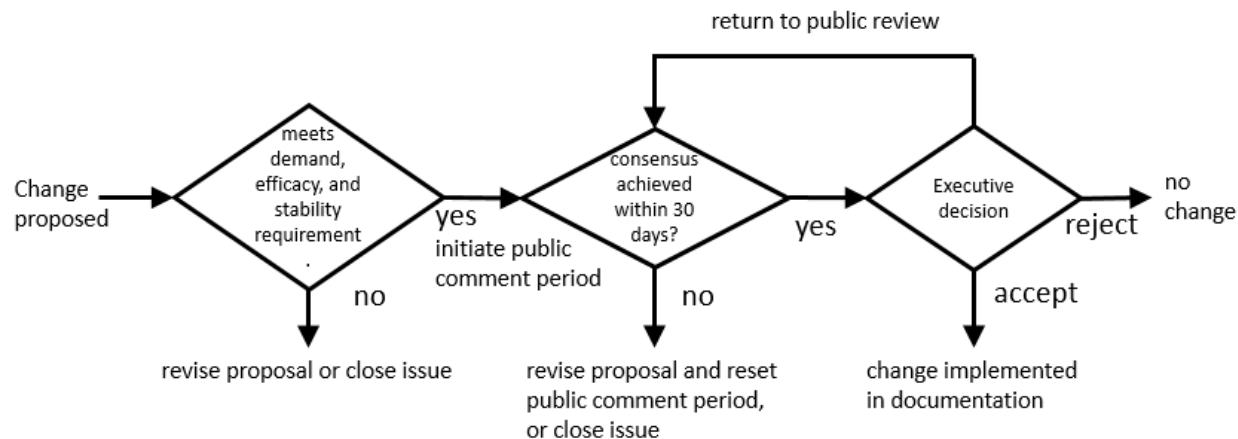
- C. With respect to schemas, there is a tradeoff between ease of maintenance (arguing for making them non-normative and easier to change) and prescribing conformity (arguing for making them normative and requiring compliance).
- D. We should decide this prior to starting the public review of the schemas so that their status can clearly be indicated in the proposal. We also need to figure out how this status will be communicated (i.e., within the schemas themselves, or only in human-readable documents that provide guidance for their use). Note: in term metadata, we've minted some tdwgutility: terms for stuff like this, e.g., tdwgutility:status of "recommended" and "superseded" (see <http://rs.tdwg.org/dwc/terms/version/recordedBy-2014-10-23.ttl> as an example). We could mint a similar term for the status of the content (normative or non-normative).

Conclusion: Seems like we want to keep the schemas non-normative to allow for easier maintenance (not every item can be held up by public review). Consider them an implementation output/dist maintained by the Maintenance Group.

Action: Find a way to indicate that the schemas are non-normative. E.g. in a landing page for the schemas.

III. Beginning the public review period for the first periodic update of DwC.

- A. The plan is to have them 3 times per year (every 4 months). So we will begin the next review in November 2026.



B.

Our task as a Maintenance Group is to approve change proposals that have achieved the demand, efficacy, and stability requirements. Because of the backlog of proposals, we need to focus on moving forward several high-priority sets of proposals that have been delayed by the lengthy DwC-DP public review. The categories are:

1. Proposals that came up during the DwC-DP review that are needed for DwC-DP to function well, but that arose too late in the review to be included in that round of changes.
2. The Mineralogy Extension terms.
3. The initial schemas that will support implementation of DwC-DP.

- C. The relevant issues are grouped in the "First post-DwC-DP release" milestone, <https://github.com/tdwg/dwc/issues?q=is%3Aissue%20state%3Aopen%20milestone%3A%22First%20post-DwC-DP%20release%22> . Because there are a large number of issues, I have bundled similar issues as sub-issues under some umbrella issues. This divides the issues into 6 groups:
1. **Maintenance issues.** These are not change proposals but are bugs or documentation errata. They are included in the milestone because we want to fix them before the changes are published in the next release. They are grouped at <https://github.com/tdwg/dwc/issues/902>
 2. **Humboldt extension terms having boolean values.** There are 11 terms that are all proposed to change in the same way: organize them under the new Survey class and recommend that the values be taken from the TDWG Controlled Vocabulary for booleans. They are grouped at <https://github.com/tdwg/dwc/issues/901>
 3. **Units issues.** Update the usage notes for "unit" terms to be consistent. Grouped at <https://github.com/tdwg/dwc/issues/925>
 4. **Mineralogy terms.** There are 13 new terms proposed to support the Mineralogy extension. To expedite moving things forward, these terms are going to be adopted into the DwC "bag of terms", making them available for use without delay. We will anticipate the production of guides for using the mineralogy extension to follow. These terms are grouped at: <https://github.com/tdwg/dwc/issues/900>
 5. **DwC-DP schemas.** The issue for discussion of the schemas themselves is <https://github.com/tdwg/dwc/issues/903> . There are several sub-issues that will need to be cleared prior to achieving consensus on the schemas themselves.
 6. **Other term proposals.** The remaining issues in the milestone involve some kind of change resulting from the DwC-DP public review. They can be viewed by excluding the sub-issues of the umbrella issues: <https://github.com/tdwg/dwc/issues?q=is%3Aissue%20state%3Aopen%20milestone%3A%22First%20post-DwC-DP%20release%22%20-parent-issue%3Atdwg%2Fdwc%23900%20-parent-issue%3Atdwg%2Fdwc%23901%20-parent-issue%3Atdwg%2Fdwc%23902%20-parent-issue%3Atdwg%2Fdwc%23903>
- D. Any of these issues deemed to have met the three requirements will be included in the public review, which will begin as soon as possible after this meeting.
NOTE: at this time we are not assessing the particular details of the proposal, just whether they meet the three requirements for going to public comment. The DwC MG members can comment and suggest changes during the review along with the rest of the community.
- E. The anticipated timeline is as follows:
1. First month: 30 days of discussion.
 2. Second month: quiet period for issues that have achieved consensus followed by Executive Committee approval.

3. Third month: implement changes and publish. Release new version of DwC.

4. Fourth month: legwork to prepare for the next public review.

Note that I've allocated 30 days for actual discussion. Any issues that haven't achieved consensus during that period will be deferred to the next round.

Discussion can continue, but we won't expect those proposals to be included in the upcoming release.

IV. Other business.

Q: should we (maybe from 2027) have a timeline that shows the public review cycle over the year?